

F25 Exhibition

La Julia Rhea

Honoring Her Historic Home



La JULIA RHEA
DRAMATIC SOPRANO

Eli(se) Davidson
Anthropology & English LTCC
AN347: Museum Studies

2914 W. 141st Place, Blue Island, Chicago, IL

Shared on La Julia Rhea's Facebook Group by Charles Tucker (2020)

Michael Golden, on March 12, 2016

"On a personal note "Madame La Julia Rhea" was one of my Junior High School Music Teachers in Robbins, Illinois. We use to hold free public concerts on the front lawn of her Mansion in Blue Island, Illinois."

Listed as an archived image of home on [Cook County, IL Property Assessor Card.](#)

Unknown who was occupying the home at the time.

La Julia Rhea's estate, as viewed from the right-hand (eastern) side. The driveway remains. Flower pots remain, their yellow paint cracking off in chunks. The green turf is bunched together on the left (western) side of the property. Pieces of her hand-made yellow tiles are scattered throughout the cinderblock rubble.



Unknown Date



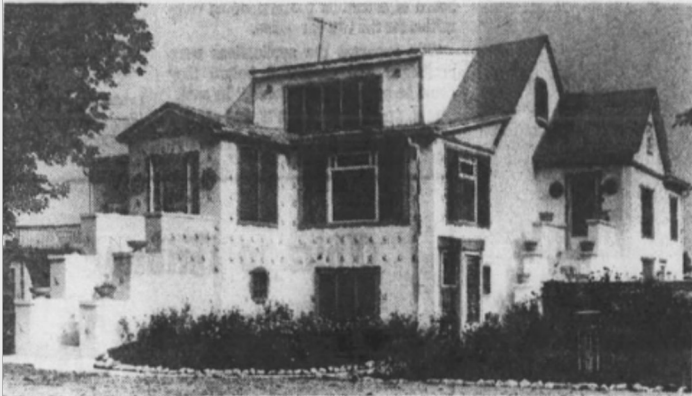
09 January 2008



24 November 2025



WAITING FOR THE 'CINDERELLA' TOUCH—This is how the bareboned structure of the Rhea house, 2914 W. 141st pl., Blue Island, looked when purchased in 1953. It was set in the midst of a 2-acre vacant lot in a then scarcely populated neighborhood.



[TRIBUNE Staff Photo by Roy B. Hall]

MONUMENTAL EFFORT—The Rhea home represents a do-it-yourself project of 14 years duration. The decorative tiles in the front of the home are yellow birds which Mrs. Rhea molded in concrete in her kitchen dishpan. The second-floor window was constructed from an old bookcase. The panes on the first floor were made from mirrors which had the silver stripped off, with old transoms installed above them.

To keep herself busy, she began looking for the "right" house, which she found in 1953, moved into in 1955, and hopes to finish remodeling this month.

One of the main features of the house is the extensive use of mirrors, especially on the ceilings. An antique grand piano was painted white and strips of mirrored-glass are inlaid along its sides.

The mouldings on the ceilings have hand-cut designs. A variety of crystal chandeliers grace each room. The glass was purchased in second-hand stores and re-strung on fixtures by Mrs. Rhea and her son.

The yard also has been the object of extensive work with a built-in table, patio, garden wall, and small pond. Lights are enclosed within glass brick so the yard can be illuminated at night.

A unique touch for the house is a white bear rug which lies snarling on the living room floor.

"We never plan to sell this home. When we die, it will go to an organization for deprived children. I would love to have them playing on the lawn long after I've gone. There's been too much hard work here to just let it be torn up," she said.

Source The Chicago Tribune, Sept. 11, 1969

But because the area was then going from white to black occupants, the Rheas were able to buy the property for \$8,200, and that price gave them a bargain-basement ticket out of Chicago's ghetto. With her husband in failing health, Rhea had to watch every penny just to make the payments. After taking care of the household bills, their weekly budget for discretionary purchases was never more than \$2 or \$3, and those economic facts of life dictated the unique architecture of their construction.

"I got to know every lumber yard and hardware store for miles around here," Bobbie Rhea explained. "They all knew our situation. So whenever they had some leftover material, instead of throwing it out, they'd give me a call."

By tacking on one such free-will offering to the next, Bobbie and Henry virtually doubled the house's original floor plan.

"No, I never had any training beyond high school wood shop," Bobbie explained. "It all began when we had to put in a boiler, so we could have some heat in the winter. The company we bought it from estimated how much it would cost to run the ducts to the various parts of the house, and I told

Source The Chicago Tribune, Feb. 26, 1986

Exhibit Background

In 2022, a vacant house at 2914 W. 141st Place in Blue Island, Illinois, was demolished. Within the rubble lay fragments of an extraordinary artistic life. The objects presented here were discovered during a visit to the property in 2025, salvaged from what remained after earlier recovery efforts. These pieces once belonged to La Julia Rhea, a lesser-known African-American soprano opera singer of the early 20th century.

Regarding the Property

La Julia Rhea purchased the wooded lot in 1955 and spent fourteen years transforming the 1929-built structure into a reflection of her aesthetic and creative vision. Working alongside her eldest son, Robert, she curated each room with carefully selected second-hand treasures that showcased their shared discerning eye and theatrical sensibilities. The home became an extension of her artistry and achievement—a stage of her own making.

Following La Julia's death in 1992, the property gradually fell into disrepair. The grass grew wild and the structure deteriorated until the house was listed for sale in 2020 at ninety thousand dollars. Two years later, reduced to a shell surrounded by overgrown weeds on Chicago's South Side, it sold for fifty thousand dollars and was demolished that same year.

Three decades after her passing, these surviving objects offer intimate glimpses into the material world of a remarkable woman. What remains from 2914 W. 141st Place tells a story that deserves preservation: how La Julia Rhea lived, the family she cherished, and the dignity she held for herself, against all odds.

Unearthed beneath leaf layer in the back northwest corner of the property.

Unknown 'Bronze' Decor, Unknown

A piece of molded plastic that mimics the iconic Victorian-era designs of ceiling medallions and various facade décor. Appears to have a bronze-like finish.

- Unknown where/what this piece would attach to. Features a singular concave slot for inserting a supporting rod. Backside is lightly textured.
 - None of the screws are real. Skeuomorphic.
- Jagged edges on both sides suggests this is a partial fragment of what could've been a full circle.
- Features fleur de lis and crown-like molding around six circular openings.





Uncovered in central north of the property; near horizontal, dead tree and thorns (rubus occidentalis)

Flush-Mount, Waterfall “Tears” Chandelier, Unknown Creator

- Rusted. Damaged branches.
- Missing the second tier, the third row of branches.
- Missing finial and central skeuomorphic band.

Second-Hand Crystal, Hand-Strung by Mme. Rhea

- Hung with delicate, 0.5mm wire.
- Fall-cut pear crystal. Unknown material.



Learning About Two Parts of a Whole Almost

Material Research



"Beautiful, working brass/metal light fixture, can be mounting to ceiling with chain and switch to turn on and off, needs restoration, but it would be a gorgeous light after it has been restored, there are brass accents on this but I do not believe it all is brass and it does look like it has been painted, has arms that come off of it that crystals can be hung off of. Measures 15 x 20 inches and has a lot of potential, just needs some care given to it. **Estate sale find.**"

Nana's Notions on Ebay
Ormond Beach, Florida

The chandelier found in 2025 **differs in more than one way**. It contains the internal wiring for the lighting, but does not have the wire hut as shown to the left. Additionally, the finial (the bottom piece. bulb) is missing; I believe these are altogether **different**. The central circular band is broken, and would've aligned with the extruding bulbs, making this chandelier lit from the inside.

1968 Waterfall, 6-Tier Brass Chandelier



After hours of searching for similar chandeliers to the damaged parts, I stumbled across this listing for a 1968 brass chandelier.

This confirmed that Mme. Rhea's chandelier was most likely a reproduction, or at least, a non-brass duplicate. Plastic molding gained popularity in the late 70s, and with the determination of all the Rhea's, I could imagine that they might have tested their hands.

Evidently, Rhea's would've had two bulbs less, and the central decor aligned with the lighting behind.

There are striking similarities, however, between the use of the fleur de lis and Victorian-esque florals and framing. While this lamp was brass, La Julia Rhea seemed to have favor chrome metals against deep mahogany fabrics with intricate gold stitching.



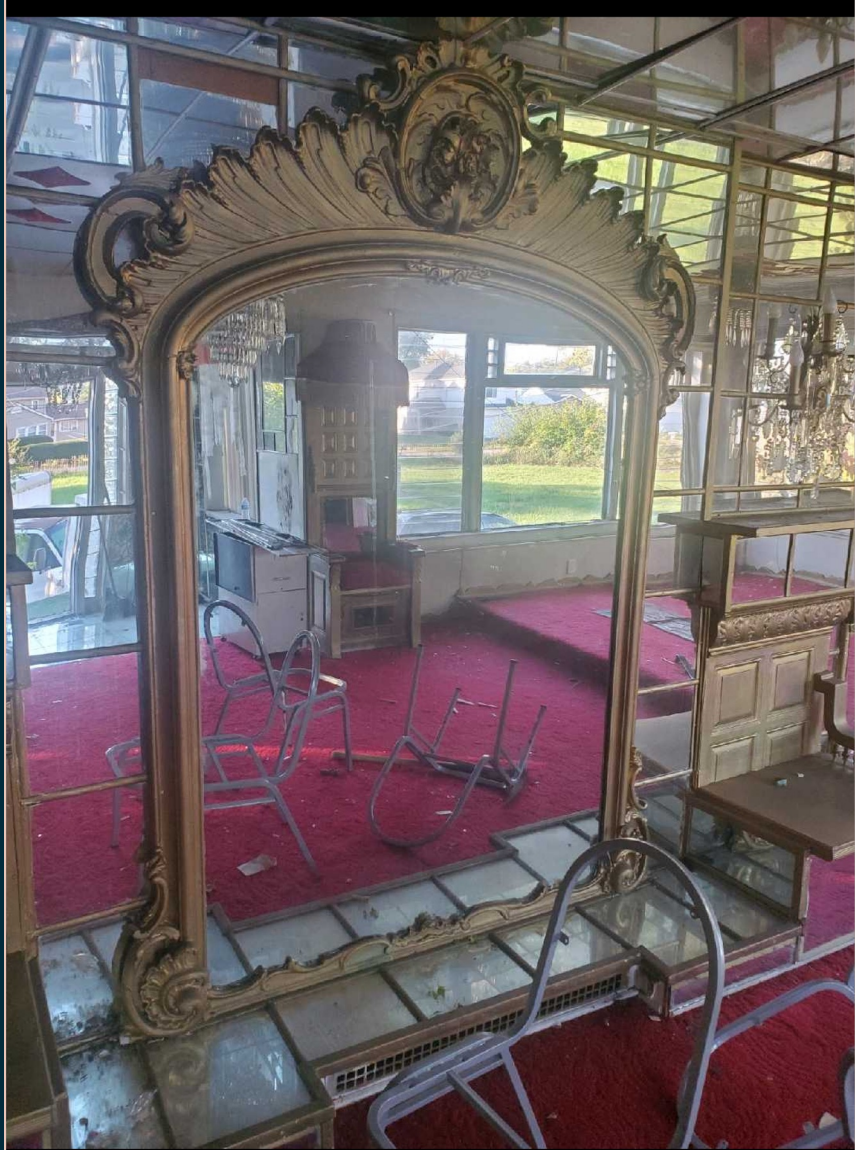
Madame La Julia Rhea's home is a fairy-tale creation of castoff treasures and her sons' ingenuity.

Source The Chicago Tribune, Feb. 26, 1986



"Mirrors...and Chandeliers. Just in from Chicago. Oh my. Still cleaning them, there's over two Dozen Old... Chandeliers, and Sconces. Two Large Mirrors. They all came from the Amazing 1920's - 40's African American Opera Singer, La Julia Rhea's, Home. ❤️❤️❤️ They're all packed into our Home, until I can get them together. I'll let you know, when they are ready to go."

Simply Iowa on Facebook, October 29, 2021



Barb C., [Simply Iowa Blog](#), October of 2021

When you handle things, that you know...meant so very much...to someone, {much like conducting Estate Sales, or...working on Old...Hand Made...Furniture}
you...kind of get to 'Know'...those people, through their 'treasures'...their 'Art'.
<3

That's exactly...what happened the other day.
By the end of the day, I was feeling pretty melancholy.
{and...III.}

When I finished putting the above Chandelier together...
noticed there were too many prisms attached.
Then...looked back on the Images Chicago Ray, had sent...while they were still hanging in La Julia's Home.
:)

Of...Course, there were too many Prisms.
:)
She...had put More Bling...on The Bling.
:) :) :)

All of her Chandeliers...had More Beads, More Prisms...than what they originally had.
<3

Remember...saying years ago...to one of my 'Show Partners'...while setting one of our booths,
"When ya think you've pushed It...
'Over The Top'...
Give 'er Another Shove."
:)

That's what La Julia did, I'd bet...in everything she did.
She was an 'Artist'.
<3

Took a video, that night...and walked through the Sea of Chandeliers.
but....also, looked around, at what John has created...here.

All I could think about...was La Julia's Home...coming down.
She passed away, in 1992, but...somehow, her death...seemed much more recent.

Then...thought about...how our 'Home'...has also been so 'butchered'.
Like...La Julia's...
nothing, will ever be the same.

If you could've heard Ray...on the phone with me...as he was
walking through...La Julia's Home,
oh my.
;)

It had been broken into...many times, over the decades.
yet...
Ray, was so impressed by it.
Kept saying...
"Barb! I Wish You Could SEE This!!"
;)

I, have...Ray. I...have.
<3

Had to get permission, from Ray's Friend, who has the Salvage
Rights, to share La Julia's name.
He was so happy, that I would.
:)

Of Course.
I Always...when allowed, Share...The History of Every Piece.
Always.
<3

Thanked them Both...for Saving what they could.
Too Much...of our History, is lost...to wrecking balls....
chain saws, backhoes, and jackhammers, for all sorts of greed,
nonsense, and
wrongfulness.

Too Much.

Barb C., [Simply Iowa Blog](#), October of 2021



Tribune photos by Bob Fila

La Julia Rhea with her sons, Henry and Bobbie, who built her castle with furnishings scavenged from demolished Gold Coast mansions. Enlarged press clippings and letters also are displayed [above].

"The family of Blue Island's La Julia Rhea, the first African American to perform in major roles in the opera, was kind enough to let us into her home today to save artifacts and images from her life and career."

Blue Island Historical Society, January 5, 2019

